

"We Cannot Escape History"

Lincoln and the Last Best Hope of Earth



**Edited by
James M. McPherson**

Chapter Eight



Abraham Lincoln— Our Ever-Present Contemporary

FRANK J. WILLIAMS

Americans are ambivalent about authority figures and heroes. Our Revolutionary past makes us skeptics, and our typical experience with political leaders tends to confirm our suspicions. Nonetheless, modern political science suggests the public's close identification with presidents.¹ Assassination and death in office undermine our skepticism and after losing presidents we tend to overcompensate and turn them into saints. Over time, however, we fall back on traditional doubts and wear presidents down while in office then turn them into saints in death, only to tear them down again later. In part this sinner-saint cycle is a way for citizens to identify with the American political tradition that is reflected in the chief executive. Garry Wills has aptly caught the saintly side of this process in the death of George Washington, and I will explore the fuller cycle in the life and death of our first assassinated president, Abraham Lincoln, whom scholars unanimously and consistently select as America's greatest president.²

Lincoln in Power: Sinner to Sainthood

The names and labels given Abraham Lincoln in his lifetime reflect how he was treated as politician. Abuse was hurled freely from the North during his first year as president. His inadequacy and vacillation were condemned widely, along with his intellect: "You cannot . . . fill his . . . empty skull with brains." He was a "political coward," "timid and ignorant," "pitiable," "too slow," "two faced," a man of "no education," "shattered, dazed, utterly foolish," "an awful, woeful ass," a "blackguard," the "craftiest and most dishonest politician that ever disgraced an office in America," a "filthy story-teller," a "halfwitted usurper," the "head ghoul at Washington," a "mold-eyed monster with a soul of leather," "Abraham Africanas I," an

"obscene clown," an "orangutan," the "present turtle at the head of government," a "slang-wanging, stump speaker," an "unmentionable disease," and the "wooden head at Washington."³ At the very least the press saw Lincoln as ambiguous, some newspapers supported him for being a liberal and some for being a conservative. Thus he was criticized regardless of his position.

The attacks continued during the Civil War and were hardly kinder in the South. Even his cabinet consisted of fellow politicians who initially shared many of these views. In a sense, the general public caught on to the Lincoln message before much elite opinion did. As David Long argues in his exhaustive analysis of the 1864 election, the public's reaction to his leadership even surprised the president, who was certain of his electoral defeat although equally convinced of his policies.⁴

Lincoln became part of the national myth before the assassination, when most people think the myth began. The letters to the president that are part of the Robert Todd Lincoln Collection in the Library of Congress show a clear progression in how Lincoln was viewed before and after he signed the preliminary Emancipation Proclamation in September 1862. After issuing the preliminary proclamation, he was regarded as something more than a mere statesman. Of course, his assassination instantly transformed the reelected president from a finally unsuccessful politician into a saint who would certainly challenge, if not surpass, George Washington's apotheosis.

Lincoln knew how to write poetic prose. At his First Inaugural, he said, "We are not enemies but friends. . . . Though passion may have strained, it must not break our bonds of affection. The mystic chords of memory, stretching from every battlefield and patriot grave to every living heart and hearthstone all over this broad land, will yet swell the chorus of the Union when again touched, as surely they will be, by the better angels of our nature."⁵

The Second Inaugural is "probably the most famous of all inaugural addresses. . . . The power of its sentiment is deepened even further when it is read as a counterpoint to the first Inaugural Address, perhaps as Lincoln meant it to be. . . . On both occasions, he cited the responsibilities of the opposing sections, North and South, as well as his own as Chief Magistrate. . . . Lincoln . . . both times appealed to the basic humanity of the nation's citizenry, hoping that 'the mystic chords of memory' would 'swell the chorus of the Union' and lead to that transcendent moment when all could say, 'With malice toward none, with charity for all.'"⁶

When peace was assured, Lincoln devoted fully half of his Second Inaugural Address to a fire-and-brimstone defense of the war as punishment sent from Heaven for the sin of slavery. He called it "strange" that both



Lincoln's greatness was not universally recognized by his contemporaries. (The Frank and Virginia Williams Collection of Lincolniana)

"The Apotheosis — George Washington Receiving Lincoln in Heaven" (The Frank and Virginia Williams Collection of Lincolniana)



sides invoked God's "aid against the other," with "the prayers . . . of neither . . . answered fully." Although convinced that the speech would "wear as well as—perhaps better than—anything" he had ever written, he was also aware that it was "not immediately popular," explaining, "Men are not flattered by being shown that there has been a difference of purpose between the almighty and them."⁷

Most people argue that the Gettysburg Address is not only his best work but also the most eloquent statement of the American political dream. The historian James Stevenson has suggested that Lincoln's life might have inspired the character of Huck Finn.⁸ The parallels to Lincoln's life found in this greatest of American novels are striking.

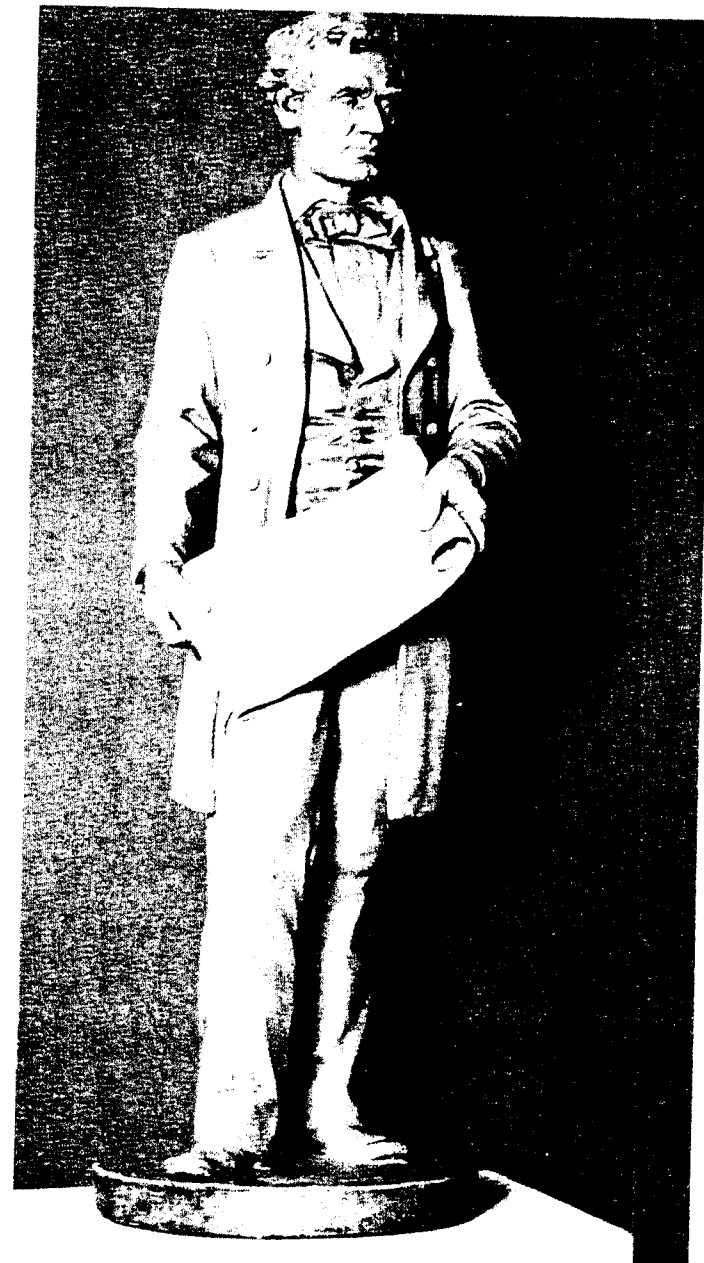
Presidential Usage: Hero and Justification

If writers were inspired and influenced by Abraham Lincoln, subsequent presidents have been too. Unfortunately, too often few subsequent presidents have truly understood Lincoln's leadership, although nearly all have tried to "get right with Lincoln," as David Donald has aptly described the process. According to Donald, Lincoln's "ambiguity" has satisfied every conceivable national and political need, even for those who hold diametrically opposed views.⁹

Theodore Roosevelt, for example, was inspired by Lincoln and identified with his life. Roosevelt's "stewardship theory" of presidential power was an extreme version of Lincoln's wartime presidency. "Great Presidents are products not just of their own talents and ambitions, but of the circumstances they inherit. Theodore Roosevelt complained frequently that his times had denied him greatness. 'A man has to take advantage of his opportunities', he said after leaving office, 'but the opportunities have to come. If there is not the war, you don't get the great general; if there is not the great occasion, you don't get the great statesman; if Lincoln had lived in times of peace, no one would know his name now.' " Despite his successful activist presidency, Roosevelt was greatly disappointed that World War I came after he had left office, and he believed that Woodrow Wilson and not he had been given the opportunity for greatness.¹⁰

C. Northcote Parkinson observed that "work expands so as to fill the time available for its completion."¹¹ Efforts of other presidents to wear Lincoln's mantle expanded, like Parkinson's law, to fill the time available for its use. Mired in the Great Depression, Herbert Hoover took solace in remembering that Lincoln had survived much abuse and still won reelection.¹²

Franklin Delano Roosevelt, not satisfied to claim Jefferson and Jackson, wanted to expropriate Abraham Lincoln for the Democratic party in an ef-



Lincoln offered the nation an adaptable vision. Statue by Leonard Volk. (The Frank and Virginia Williams Collection of Lincolniana)

fort to win votes, particularly those of blacks.¹³ Roosevelt invoked Lincoln's name at every possible opportunity, placing himself in a direct line of political descent from the martyred railsplitter, and during the presidential campaign of 1948 Harry S. Truman asserted that a twentieth-century Lincoln would clearly have been a regular Democrat.¹⁴

In delivering his farewell to the people of Massachusetts, President-elect John F. Kennedy consciously imitated Lincoln's Farewell Address to his friends in Springfield and did not object when his civil rights bill was termed the Second Emancipation Proclamation. Lyndon B. Johnson compared his Vietnam War ordeal to that of Abraham Lincoln, as did Richard M. Nixon, who visited the Lincoln Memorial late at night during Watergate to commune with his predecessor.¹⁵

During the 1992 presidential race, Lincoln seemed to belong to both Bill Clinton and George Bush. Clinton, at the time of the Gennifer Flowers revelation, was seen leafing through the books *Lincoln on Democracy* and *Lincoln on Leadership*, and Bush compared himself to Lincoln, "a lonely White House occupant."¹⁶ Perhaps because the president is a symbol of national unity and stability, Lincoln is used shamelessly for political ends: Clinton has quoted Lincoln to justify activist government; many encouraged Bush to dump Dan Quayle as his vice-presidential running-mate, citing Lincoln's replacement of Hannibal Hamlin; and William F. Buckley, Jr., advised American voters not to ignore George Bush just "because he is not Abraham Lincoln."¹⁷

And then there was the case of former President Ronald Reagan, who brought a hushed and reverential silence to the 1992 Republican National Convention by invoking "Lincoln's words": "You cannot strengthen the weak by weakening the strong, you cannot help the wage-earner by pulling down the wage-payer. You cannot help the poor by destroying the rich. You cannot help men permanently by doing for them what they could and should do for themselves." The problem was, however, that these words were written not by Lincoln but by a former clergyman from Erie, Pennsylvania, in 1916. They were used from time to time during the 1930s by anti-New Deal businessmen and in 1942 by the right-wing Committee for Constitutional Government. Then, in 1950, Representative Frances Bolton of Ohio read them into the *Congressional Record* as Lincoln's maxims, and *Look* magazine gave them a full-page spread. "There seems to be no way," a Library of Congress report observed in May 1950, of stopping the proliferation of the mistaken attribution.¹⁸

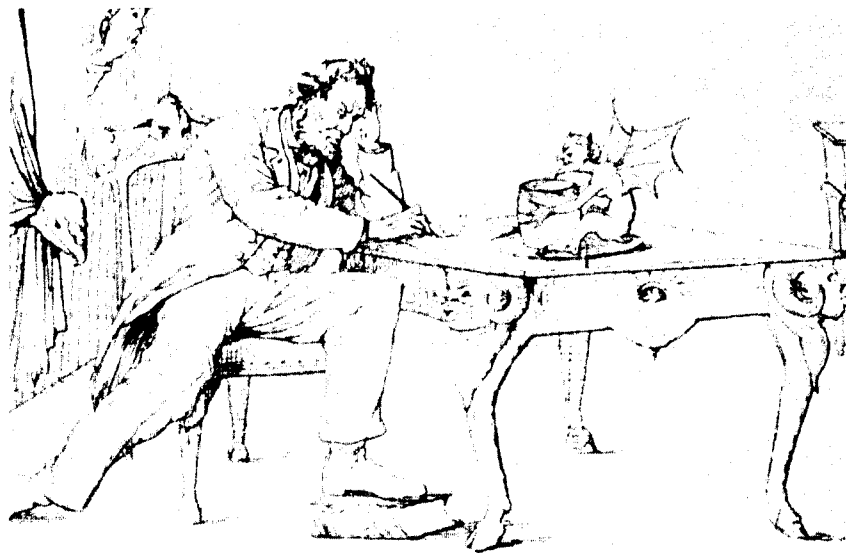
To Robert Hughes, an Australian, "if the collective work that is America . . . is broken, the possibilities of Americanness begin to unravel. If they are fraying now, it is because the politics of ideology has, for the last twenty years, weakened, and, in some areas, broken the traditional American gen-

ius for consensus." Hughes maintains that "Reagan educated America down to his level. He left his country a little stupider in 1988 than it had been in 1980, and a lot more tolerant of lies." It did not matter, argues Hughes that Reagan misquoted Lincoln because, "who was counting? For Reagan's fans, the idea that there ought to be, . . . some . . . relationship between utterance and source seemed impertinent to the memory of his presidency. . . . This was not . . . Presidential character that . . . Lincoln . . . [could] . . . imagine—or . . . respect."¹⁹ Reagan was drawn to the Lincoln he envisioned and, as a result, did not portray him accurately. The press, with its own picture of Lincoln, was quick to expose the misrepresentation.²⁰

Thirty years after John F. Kennedy's farewell remarks were compared to Lincoln's, Bill Clinton left for Washington with yet another Lincolnesque (or at least Lincoln-inspired) farewell. Lincoln said on leaving Springfield: "My friends—No one, not in my situation, can appreciate my feeling of sadness at this parting. To this place, and the kindness of these people, I owe every thing. . . . I now leave, not knowing when, or whether ever, I may return, with a task before me greater than that which rested upon Washington. Without the assistance of the Divine Being, . . . I cannot succeed. With that assistance, I cannot fail. . . . let us confidently hope that all will yet be well. To His care commending you, as I hope in your prayers you will commend me, I bid you an affectionate farewell." Clinton said on leaving Little Rock: "I'll miss my whole network of friends and what I can do. I'll miss going down to the Y in the morning, my blue-collar gym, where there's nobody in bright Spandex outfits. I have a lot of friends in Washington. I think I'll enjoy it a lot."²¹ Of course, Lincoln sounds better than Clinton, but Harold Holzer has observed that much of Lincoln's reputation as an orator—especially in the Lincoln-Douglas Debates—was a myth.

Has the nation's view of leadership and the presidency changed? George Bush was never able to overcome the reversal of his no-new-taxes pledge. When he did support additional taxes, he "invoked" the words of Lincoln, explaining, "I'm doing like Lincoln did, 'think anew,'" quoting from the president's annual message to Congress on December 1, 1862 in which Lincoln not only called for restoration of the Union but also for freeing the slaves. During his 1860 campaign, Lincoln had vowed that the federal government should not interfere with slavery where it existed.²²

Americans reelected Lincoln; they were less charitable to George Bush. Still, Lincoln's contemporaries did not universally recognize his greatness. As time passes, citizens perceive and evaluate presidents in terms of their stands on issues, party connections, leadership qualities, including record and experience, and personal qualities.²³ Time and reflection have been better to Abraham Lincoln than to most presidents, despite their real and Machiavellian identification with him.



Today, some view Lincoln as far from perfect for using less than noble methods to achieve his goals. Portrait by Adalbert and Johann Volck, "Writing the Emancipation Proclamation." Volck was a Copperhead from Baltimore. (The Frank and Virginia Williams Collection of Lincolniana)

Perhaps we should not be too harsh on presidential use of Lincoln, for his successors merely try to come to terms with the person who has set the standard for presidential leadership and perhaps democratic leadership in general. Lincoln satisfies every international need: Lincoln the nationalist (for the early-nineteenth-century Italians trying to form a nation), Lincoln the democrat (for the early-nineteenth-century French), and Lincoln the libertarian (for his few English admirers at the time of his presidency). From this worldview it is possible to understand how a young Chinese boy learned about Abraham Lincoln at a school in Honolulu and then remembered the Gettysburg Address when he returned home. Sun Yat Sen went on to become the first president of modern China and turned to the declaration when formulating his political creed, "San min chu-yi" (three people's principles), which correspond with "of the people [Min you], by the people [Min chih], and for the people [Min hsiang]." ²⁴

Richard N. Current has reported that when he was in India in 1959 on the occasion of the Lincoln sesquicentennial people made constant comparison between Lincoln and Gandhi, almost always to Gandhi's advantage,

although a Lion's Club member in Patna assured Current that there would have been no partition of Pakistan from India had Lincoln been in charge.

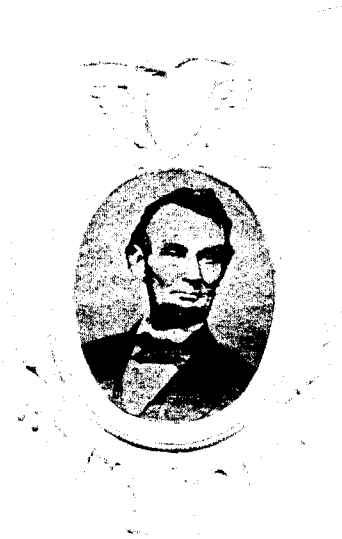
There is plenty of Lincoln to go around. He is in Poland, too, thanks to Mario M. Cuomo.²⁵ When the Baltic states seceded from the Soviet Union, some thought that doing so was contrary to the principals of the Union Lincoln espoused. Eric Foner, a Fulbright professor at Moscow University in 1990, has observed that Lincoln, like Gorbachev, would have opposed the independence of the Baltic states, the implication being that the United States was inconsistent in opposing Confederate independence 1861 and favoring Baltic independence in 1990. However, there is a great difference between the United States in 1861 and the Soviet Union in 1991. "If the Union means the willing consent of people to forge a common destiny, the Soviet Union died long ago. Its government no longer represented a majority anywhere." To put it in terms of the United States in 1861, it would have been as if "all of the states had sought to secede." This is no contradiction, because Gorbachev's role was to preside over dissolving a Union, whereas Lincoln is rightly honored for saving one.²⁶

Pop Culture and Lincoln

If subsequent presidents have found it difficult to meet Lincoln's performance standard, the general public must contend with the Lincoln standard enshrined in the Lincoln Memorial and on Mount Rushmore. Like ordinary presidents, ordinary mortals find it difficult to grapple with a saintly stature and so reduce it to their level. Even if doing so diminishes the heroic, it at least shows the struggle that later generations have in coming to terms with quality.

The contrast is found, for example, in Gutzon Borglum's statue of Lincoln in Newark, New Jersey; Lincoln is shown seated on a bench, which allows the public to share space and thoughts with him. The work is clearly a tribute to Lincoln, and it captures his spirit. In contrast, the J. Seward Johnson, Jr., statute unveiled in Gettysburg in November 1991 portrays Lincoln with an anonymous figure. The public is excluded from interacting with the piece. Its intent is commercial, an effort to sell Gettysburg tourism. This is not a tribute to Lincoln, but an appropriation of his good name.

The emphasis on Lincoln's rise from poverty, the journey from log cabin to White House, has been superseded by a fragmented view of a sick man who suffered from depression and Marfan's Syndrome. The National Museum of Health and Science has recommended testing a sample of Lincoln's blood to determine his DNA, prompting one commentator to ask, "Can Abraham Lincoln's DNA be cloned? . . . not to diagnose his diseases, but



Every generation makes its own Lincoln. Carte de visite issued by Salisbury, Bro. & Co., Providence, R.I. (The Frank and Virginia Williams Collection of Lincolniana)

to fill today's leadership gap."²⁷ The museum tabled the issue until, it said, testing is perfected, but perhaps it also feared being made the butt of jokes. Too late. The *Weekly World News*, a tabloid, reported on October 5, 1993 that doctors at Walter Reed Army Medical Hospital had exhumed Lincoln's body, immersed it in a "special solution," and then injected a "resurrection drug." Lincoln was said to have been revived for ninety-five seconds, time enough to ask, "Gentlemen, where am I?"²⁸

Yet, Philip B. Kunhardt, Jr., and Philip B. Kunhardt III's ABC miniseries *Lincoln* and Ken Burns's PBS series *The Civil War* are part of television's "latest programming twist: the history lesson. Documentary-makers and their corporate patrons are simultaneously feeding and exploiting a burgeoning appetite for the stuff of America's past."²⁹ Traditionally, history draws big audiences on a regular basis.

The television view of Lincoln reaches millions. But what view? Documents aside, with all of the great Lincoln plays available for production and televising, all the viewing audience saw on April 21, 1991 was "A Perfect Tribute," which centered more on the story of a young boy who leaves home to find his Confederate brother than on President Lincoln.³⁰

The avoidance of Lincoln's racial views in the Kunhardts' production of "Lincoln" in December 1992 also contributes to this reworking and, perhaps, represents a social statement about the nation's reluctance to face racism.³¹ Forty percent of the documentary was devoted to the assassination, dem-

onstrating the enormous fascination people have with Lincoln's death, an interest to which the authors and producers evidently felt compelled to pander. Consider, for example, the popularity and large membership of the Surratt Society, a group dedicated to remembering fondly the woman who, at the very least, housed the assassination conspirators. For some, there is really no rational or academic reason for such a group. Some argue this similar to those who hallucinate over the Kennedy assassination or discover Elvis at the laundromat.

How we think about Lincoln tells us much about our culture. Anyone impersonating Napoleon is assumed to be slightly mad. Yet the Association of Lincoln Impersonators has more than eighty-six card-carrying Lincoln portrayers and a newsletter, *Lincarnations*. To support the impersonators, the Friends of the Presidential Entourage of Abraham Lincoln has been formed, complete with its own quarterly newsletter, *The Reviewing Stand*. People want to be entertained if they cannot understand; in either case, Lincoln makes people feel good. With so much culture shock from Lincoln being recast in the modern image, can we do no better than a Lincoln impersonator rolling down the highway in a Winnebago that looks like a log home? Each generation makes its own Lincoln, and he may not be the Lincoln known before.

The 1960s brought Disney's animated Lincoln. "Fantasy has been entirely abandoned," said Disney of his then immensely popular life-size, automated Lincoln, which first performed in the Illinois pavilion at the 1964 New York World's Fair. For Disney, the homage was no gimmick but a new art form, "audio-animatronics," which, he believed, would "combine the best of traditional media to capture the real countenance, the warm sincerity, and the contagious dedication of Abraham Lincoln." Yet even Disney's Lincoln suffered from revision.³² In 1990, Disneyland's officials planned to close "Great Moments with Mr. Lincoln" and replace him with Kermit the Frog until tourist and park employees rebelled. As one boy said, "Lincoln was President. Kermit is a frog."³³ As with historians, Lincoln remains at the top of the popular culture polls; Disneyland held an "election" and he defeated Kermit.³⁴

Nor is Lincoln ignored in literary and dramatic humor. In his one-act play *The Query*, Woody Allen presents a Lincoln who uses his press secretary as a straight man, getting him to ask at a press conference, "Mr. President, how long do you think a man's legs should be?" "Long enough to reach the ground," Lincoln responds. Caught up in the laughter, he ignores a distraught father waiting to see him to seek a pardon for his son.³⁵ And the bane of academicians is that people everywhere wonder what Lincoln would do if he were alive today. In 1984 James M. McPherson appeared on a radio station in Wilmington after speaking to the Lincoln

Group of Delaware. The first question he was asked was, "If Lincoln were alive today, what position would he take on abortion and the budget deficit?"³⁶

Minority Groups: Emancipator, Oppressor, and Equal

In some ways the most interesting use of Lincoln has been by emerging social and political groups, African Americans, the women's movement, the men's movement, and the gay pride movement, for example. The full circle of the saint-sinner cycle is clearest in the long African-American struggle to achieve equality. For example, the records of the Federal Writers Project in Washington, D.C., contain a recollection by a former slave, Fanny Burdock of Valdosta, Georgia, who was born in the 1840s:

We been picking in the field when my brother he point to the road and then we seen Marse Abe coming all dusty on foot. We run right to the fence and had the oak bucket and dipper. When he draw up to us, he so tall, black eyes so sad. Didn't say not one word, just looked hard at all us, every one us crying. We give him nice cool water from the dipper. Then he nodded and set off and we just stood there till he get to being dust then nothing. After, didn't our owner or nobody credit it, but me and all my kin, we knowed. I still got the dipper to prove it.

Allan Gurganus's novel *The Oldest Living Confederate Widow Tells All* begins with that very recollection and then points out, "In reality, Lincoln's foot tour of Georgia could not have happened. In this book, it can. Such scenes were told by hundreds of slaves. Such visitations remain, for me, truer than fact. History is my starting point."³⁷

The African-American perception of Lincoln is varied and ambiguous. Joseph Fowlkes, past president of the Providence Chapter of the NAACP, has said that the Emancipation Proclamation "was almost bogus, a lot of sound and fury, but there was no real enforcement power behind it."³⁸ He obviously had not read the results of Mark Neely's research in the National Archives that reveals that Union commanders in the field dealt harshly with slave owners, including sentences of death for those who failed to obey or recognize the proclamation. And John Hope Franklin believes that "It [the proclamation] was momentous. . . . There was no chance slavery could survive after that." Barbara Fields contends the slaves emancipated themselves, further contributing to the reworking of Lincoln's image as the Great Emancipator. Another attempt to answer the question of who freed the slaves comes from James M. McPherson, who credits Lincoln, primarily because he would have war rather than allow secession.



African-Americans' perception of Lincoln has gone through many revisions over the years. "Lincoln and the Contrabands" by J. L. G. Ferris. (The Frank and Virginia Williams Collection of Lincolniana)



By E. Nash, 1908. The Frank and Virginia Williams Collection of Lincolniana)

And without Civil War there would have been “no confiscation act, no Emancipation Proclamation, no Thirteenth Amendment, certainly no self-emancipation and almost certainly no end of slavery for several more decades.”³⁹

Lincoln’s contemporary ups and downs with the black community began in the 1960s when *Ebony* published “Was Abe Lincoln a White Supremacist?” The reply was in the affirmative, citing doubtful evidence and using selectivity and more than some misrepresentation.⁴⁰ Conceding that historians can judge the past, one can still doubt the fairness of a verdict based entirely on ex post facto standards.⁴¹

The ultimate irony may be that in the African-American struggle to achieve equality Lincoln has been democratized to the point that his presidency has been reduced to Warren Harding’s, with the recent advent of Presidents’ Day replacing the observation of the birthdays of George Washington and Abraham Lincoln.

American Heritage Magazine, in the October 1992 issue, explored whether any historical novel may be true history. In a continuation of his thrust against Lincoln “scholar squirrels,” Gore Vidal also argues that the past cannot be left to “hagiographers” too narrow to grasp the mind of Lincoln fully. He contends that his *Lincoln: A Novel* (1984) is grounded in historical sources. Yet historians have accused Vidal of gross distortions and inaccuracies in his depiction of Lincoln as “coarse-grained and devious, ignorant of economics, disregardful of the Constitution, fiercely ambitious, and a racist until the end.” Vidal also has been said to have relied on outdated and discredited bits of scholarship and oversimplified complex issues. Although agreeing that he “embellished here and there,” Vidal has insisted that he used primary sources.⁴² He has pointed out that Americans prefer films based upon romanticized episodes from the lives of such European royalty as Henry VIII, Elizabeth I, or Napoleon but have no interest in Lincoln’s presidency.⁴³

The gay issue is not to be ignored, either. Consider Robert Bly’s discussion of whether gays should be allowed in the military. Among the highland Mayans in Guatemala, Bly has found, knowledge is presented in four stages for men: the boy, the warrior, the community man, and the “echo” man. The step from boy to warrior is fundamental, and although he is admired, the young warrior is still not considered a finished male. The community man lives for the community, taking care of widows and orphans and using his earlier developed warrior disciplines to protect them. The last stage, the “echo” man is a person who hears; he is all ears, all grief, all intuition, and all responsive to sound. The Gettysburg Address is the speech of a true “echo” person. In speaking of a debt to forefathers and to



From a daguerreotype by N. H. Shepherd, Springfield, Illinois, 1846, the earliest known photograph of Lincoln. (The Frank and Virginia Williams Collection of Lincolniana)

the living and to the soldiers who have just died, he hears grief. Bly attempts to mitigate the military’s fears of gays: “We justly admire and value the warrior, but we need not act on all of his fears. Having a wider vision, we can bless the warriors and keep the sad and echoing face of Lincoln before us.”⁴⁴

Bruce Miroff prefers the more open, nurturing style of democratic leaders like Abraham Lincoln and FDR, who emphasized “mutuality in place of superiority, education in place of dominance.” To him, such democratic leaders rejected the swaggering macho style of Kennedy or Teddy Roosevelt in favor of a softer, more feminine style. To Miroff, Lincoln belongs to the leadership that “should have the strength of purpose and tenacity of will that American culture has generally designated as masculine, but also the sensitivity, openness, and willingness to nurture others, that American culture has typically disparaged as women’s ways.”⁴⁵

Conclusions

A review of the sinner-saint cycle suggests why Abraham Lincoln remains an ever-lasting contemporary. His performance in the White House set the standard of presidential—and democratic—leadership. If subsequent presidents, pop culture, and minority groups have a difficult time grappling



Lincoln offers compatibility to everyone: laborers, business people, racists, and antiracists. "The Rail Splitter, 1830" by J. L. G. Ferris. (The Frank and Virginia Williams Collection of Lincolniana)

with a saint, their abuse and misuse of the Lincoln standard should not be judged too harshly. After all, historians have also created idealized versions of Lincoln in prose and poetry as well as revisionist accounts.⁴⁶

Of course, Abraham Lincoln began the cycle himself. He was a common person who became uncommon, a Machiavellian politician who became a statesman. His leadership style is one of America's greatest gifts to democracy. Preservation of the Union grew into a democratic justification for self-government's emphasis on dignity and equality as necessary for self-realization. He matured as a political leader, fulfilling himself in the public eye and extending the democratic burden to everyone, a contemporary and the personification of "the last best hope of Earth."

Notes

This chapter is a revised version of a talk presented at the Huntington conference with the use of 140 slide illustrations. I am indebted to William D. Pederson of Louisiana State University-Shreveport for his indispensable editorial help in preparing the talk for publication.

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